MOUNTAIN REVIEW

OFFICIAL NEWSLETTER OF THE MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

Volume XI Issue IV Autumn 2021



Page 4
One Acre and Independence, the story of Mountain View's "Chickentown"



Page 6
Recap and photos from our summer events!



Page 8
History Happening Now: The Ameswell Hotel highlights local history

Walking Tours of Historic DOWNTOWN MOUNTAIN VIEW



Fall 2021 Event

Step into history!

Sunday, November 7, marks the 119th anniversary of the City of Mountain View's incorporation and to celebrate, we invite you to join us for our Fall Event: Walking tours of the historic heart of our community, Downtown Mountain View!

Tours will be led by members of the MVHA Board of Directors who are looking forward to sharing Downtown Mountain View's 150+ year evolution by telling the stories of historic sites and buildings on and around Castro Street. Tour stops and historic information have been compiled and curated by our past president and Mountain View historian, Nicholas Perry.

All tours will begin at Centennial Plaza at 600 W. Evelyn Avenue. Registration is required to secure your spot. When you register, you'll be able to pick your tour time, with the first tour starting at 12:30 p.m. and the final tour starting at 3:00 p.m. The standard tour will be approximately one mile and one hour long and will cover historic sites along Castro Street, ending near Eagle Park. A few of our tour guides have also offered to give an optional extended version of the tour, which will continue from Eagle Park and cover important historic sites on Downtown's side streets, ending back at Centennial Plaza. Tours will be limited to 12 people and will be entirely outdoors (face coverings optional, per SCC Health Guidelines).

Register online at:
http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com or call (650) 903-6890.

Space is limited!

Reserve your spot at:

http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com
or call (650) 903-6890

In the event of rain, this event may be rescheduled ...fingers crossed for drought-ending rainy season, just not on November 7!

Sunday, November 7, 2021 ● See Above for Tour Times ● Centennial Plaza, 600 W. Evelyn Avenue Mtn. View

MOUNTAIN REVIEW

This newsletter is published four times a year by the
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042
www.mountainviewhistorical.org

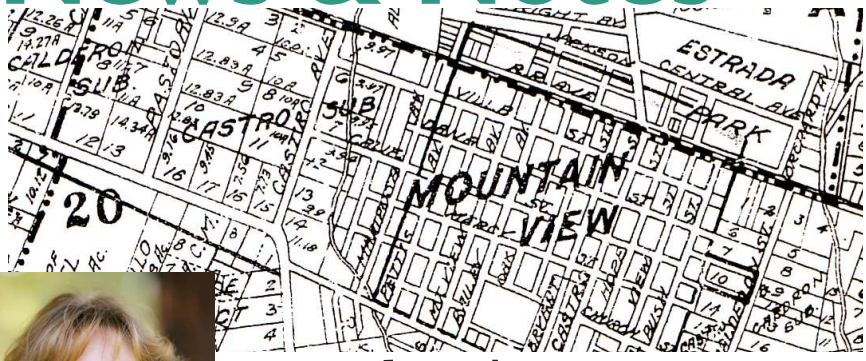
MVHA Board of Directors

President: Pamela Baird
Vice-President: Robert Cox
Secretary: Jamil Shaikh
Treasurer: Emily Ramos
Past President: Nicholas Perry
Historical Data: Candace Bowers
Publicity: Marina Marinovich
Membership: IdaRose Sylvester
Newsletter: John Cortez
Ways & Means: Mark Perry
Director-at-Large: Lisa Garcia
Director-at-Large: Gil Lane

Newsletter Copy Editor: Cynthia Hanson
Newsletter Graphic Designer: Nicholas Perry

MVHA Board of Directors
Email: info@mountainviewhistorical.org
Voicemail: (650) 903-6890

News & Notes





Pamela Baird

President's Message

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

What shows on a map?

Recently, my husband and I participated in a guided tour of Zion, Bryce, and the North Rim of the Grand Canyon national parks. There was a lot of driving, which meant we looked at maps to learn the layout of the parks. We also viewed geological cut-through diagrams to learn about the incredible history of these parks.

As we drove along, I started to think about maps—how they're surveyed and produced, and what they describe. Many civilizations have struggled to create representations of local and faraway topography to facilitate trade, travel, and treaties.

Wikipedia describes cartography as "the study and practice of making and using maps. Combining science, aesthetics and technique, cartography builds on the premise that reality (or an imagined reality) can be modeled in ways that communicate spatial information effectively."

On a wall in the basement of my maternal grandparents' home in southwest Iowa was unusual map of the western United States. It showed the cattle drive trail routes of the West. The map was a solid dark blue with the trails printed in off-white. My grandfather raised cattle, which is probably why it was there. Every time I visited, I would look at the map, with its unusual coloring, and wonder about those cattle drives and where they went. It's odd that none of my six cousins remember that map!

Recently, I was in the History Center at the MV Library doing research for the Wyandotte Park project. There was a 1954 street atlas on one of the tables. In reviewing it I looked at the pages where our townhouse is located. To my surprise, across Middlefield Road (now the Monte Loma neighborhood) was the Mountain View Airstrip. I had never heard about this before! Evidently, the unpaved airstrip was there for about twenty years.

Martha Wallace, a member of the Friends of "R" House, recently provided great research on the previous landowners of the Wyandotte Park area. Her careful use of several maps helps clarify the history. This interesting story is included.

A new member of MVHA, Eric Flint, has volunteered to write an article (and perhaps a regular column) about using maps for research. He has become quite fascinated about the many resources available. His first article is included in this issue.

It makes one wonder about the layers of history in our area and what we don't know about our immediate surroundings. What can you find?

—Pamela



MVHA board members at our Downtown Mtn. View walking tour training.

MVHA Board Updates

By Nicholas Perry
MVHA Past President

Your MVHA Board of Directors continues to work on a wide range of exciting projects! Updates below:

Los Altos History Museum Exhibit: We continued our collaboration with the Los Altos History Museum (LAHM), providing input on elements of Mountain View history to incorporate into their new permanent exhibit. One of the recent highlights of this collaboration was connecting the LAHM to the family of Joe Perez, Mountain View's first Mexican American councilmember. We're excited that Perez's inspiring story, from a childhood working as a migrant farmworker in the orchards of Los Alto to becoming mayor of Mountain View, will be included in a part of the LAHM exhibit that profiles the lives of prominent figures from our area's past. The Perez family provided us with digital copies of photos of Joe to include in the exhibit and which we will also add to our own archives.

Interpretive Signage: We continue to help the City of Mountain View research content for new interpretive signage at historic sites in the city. This edition of the newsletter highlights some of the research we've done for an interpretive sign at the new Wyandotte Park (see page 4). We also provided information for a new historic marker at the site of Mountain View's historic Chinatown near Villa and View streets in Downtown Mountain View.

MVHS Monument. We continue to build upon our partnership with Mountain View High School alumni who are working to install a monument at Eagle Park dedicated to the high school and its remarkable underdog 1975 championship football team. Our subcommittee is making progress on formalizing the MVHA's role in the project. Stay tuned for more information in our next newsletter.

Downtown Walking Tour Manual. Although I'll be out of town during our November 7 Downtown Mountain View walking tour event, I enjoyed putting together an in-depth training manual for our tour guides to use. The manual includes information and photos of 18 historic sites on and around Castro Street. We conducted a test run of the tour on October 3, and your newly trained MVHA Board tour guides are looking forward to sharing the tour with you! Our hope is to eventually offer a recurring walking tour program, but we'll need to grow our roster of volunteer tour guides. If you're interested, contact us!

Questions or want to get involved? Please don't hesitate to reach out to any one of your friendly MVHA Board members. We can be reached at info@mountainviewhistorical.org.

Financial Report

By Emily Ramos
MVHA Treasurer

Checking Account Balance as of 7/3/2021: $22,706.50
Income: $228.12
Expenses: $627.50
Checking Account Balance as of 10/6/2021: $22,307.12

Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 7/3/2021: $60,519.62
Certificates of Deposit Balance as of 10/6/2021: $60,519.62

Finding Your Family History

By Robert Cox
MVHA Vice President

Genealogy has grown to be the #1 hobby in America. Its modern resurgence follows the publication of *Roots* by Alex Haley and the subsequent 1977 TV mini-series. The hobby received a second boost with the advent of genetic genealogy, popularized by Ancestry, which also provides tools to help customers search archives of historical documents and find references to their long-forgotten ancestors.

Many people think, "I'd like to know more about my family history, but where do I begin?" The first and most important part of your research is to start talking to family members, so you can document what they already know. In my decades of working on my family history, the most common regretful refrain I have heard is: "I wish I'd talked to my parents or grandparents while I still had the chance."

There are a few guidelines you can follow to having conversations with your older family members that will yield useful genealogical information. First, find the members that are interested in talking, and make the interview process as pleasant for them as possible. Often bringing a small gift or inviting your interviewees out for lunch can help build a connection, making that person more likely to open up. Above all, show that you appreciate them and their time. Second, recognize that every family has its "surprising" stories. While I've found one or two family members who like to shock others by blurting out these stories, more often it takes several conversations before family members are comfortable enough to share their stories with you. Take notes, if possible, but do it in a way that doesn't offend the interviewee. Write down everything you've learned after an interview. Also, understand that no one's knowledge of the past is perfect. Our understanding of our family history is always evolving, and it's necessary to cross-check everything we learn with documents and other sources of information.

In my next column, I'll talk about the best free online sources of family history information.



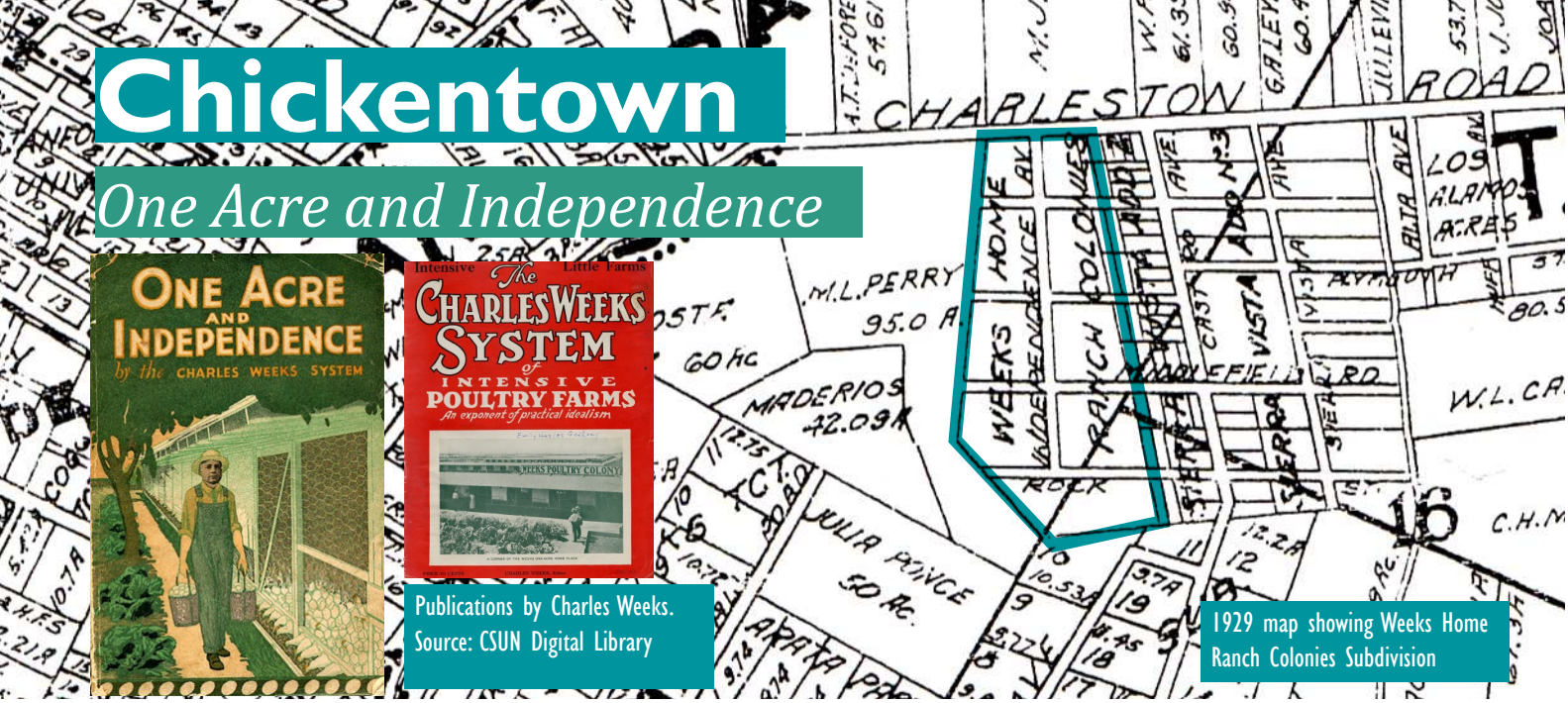
Earl Askam as Officer Torch

Mtn. View Family History Fun Fact!
Earl Leslie Rengstorff Askam (1891-1940), a grandson of Mountain View pioneer Henry Rengstorff, played Officer Torch in Universal's *Flash Gordon* science fiction movie series.

Chickentown

One Acre and Independence

Publications by Charles Weeks. Source: CSUN Digital Library



1929 map showing Weeks Home Ranch Colonies Subdivision

By Martha Wallace
Special Contributor

In October 2020, a new Mountain View neighborhood park opened on Wyandotte Street. The park includes sculptures of carved stone chickens. In looking at a map one sees that the neighboring street names are those of chicken breeds: Wyandotte, Plymouth, Leghorn, and Rock. What's the history of the Wyandotte Park area?

Ohlone Indians were the first known residents, living in small villages, fishing, hunting, and gathering. Then Spanish land grantees and priests cultivated the land and raised cattle. José Peña received permission from the Santa Clara Mission to occupy the land in 1830. In 1841, the Mexican government granted Rancho Rincón de San Francisquito to Peña. He sold the land to Teodoro and Secundino Robles in 1847. After statehood, the Robles brothers filed a claim with the Public Land Commission in 1852, which was patented in 1868.

The gold rush brought people from all over the world, including Henry Rengstorff from Germany in 1850. In the Shoreline area, he built a bayside landing and warehouse for scow schooners, facilitating shipping to and from San Francisco. He purchased farm and ranch land, including part of the Robles rancho south of Charleston Road.

An 1876 map showed the Rengstorff land south of Charleston Road, with neighboring properties owned by the Swall, Huff, Stierlin, Levin, Castro, and Calderon families. By 1903, streets from town and the railroad were built out toward the Rengstorff farm: Calderon (through the Calderon property) and Pastoria (through the Castro rancho, Pastoria de las Borregas). Calderon is now Thompson Avenue; Pastoria became Castro, now Rengstorff Avenue.

Mountain View Records from 1923 show that Rengstorff's son, Henry Andrew Rengstorff, and others gave consent to a subdivision plan for the Sierra Vista Addition, Weeks Home Ranch Colonies. Evidently, Henry sold some of his land to Charles Weeks, an interesting figure in California history.

Charles Weeks was a poultry expert. He came from Indiana in 1904, settled in Los Altos, and in 1909, moved to Crescent Park in Palo Alto where he introduced the Weeks Poultry Method, and through various publications spread the word about his self-sustaining lifestyle. People visited his ranch to learn his new method of raising poultry: concentrating birds into coops and using shared technologies, facilities, and marketing, within a social community of common interests. In 1916, Weeks established the community of Runnymede, now part of East Palo Alto, where he put his utopian ideals to practice, creating one-and-a-half-acre parcels across 600 acres. The subdivision was marketed to "gentlemen farmers" who Weeks sold on the idea of making a living raising hens on their properties, while still leaving room for small homes, fruit trees, and grape vines.

In the 1920s, Weeks expanded his concept to Mountain View. The Weeks Home Ranch Colonies subdivision was centered on a new street named "Independence Avenue," likely in reference to his motto, "One Acre and Independence." The cross streets were named after chicken breeds: Wyandotte, Plymouth, Leghorn, and Rock. In April of 1923, the Mountain View colony lots went on sale. This area came to be known as "Chickentown" because of the prevalence of poultry raising. Of the 37 people living in the area who listed an occupation in the 1930 census, fourteen were chicken farmers and wholesale egg dealers. By 1940 only six in the area listed poultry farming as a livelihood. The Great Depression severely impacted the business model promoted by Weeks and resulted in the failure of many of his poultry colonies.

As for Weeks, around the same time the Mountain View colonies were created, he turned his attention toward establishing a new colony in the San Fernando Valley of Los Angeles. Weeks eventually retired to Florida, where he reportedly lived out the remainder of his life growing papayas, raising fishing worms, and skin diving, until his death in 1964 at the age of 91.

Today, Mountain View's Chickentown is a mix of storage units, townhouse complexes, and shops at the Rengstorff Center. This eclectic mix of land uses can be partly attributed to the narrow but deep parcels Weeks created for raising hens here, which limited the ability for developers to create larger developments and subdivisions like those built elsewhere in Mountain View's former countryside, where large orchard ranches and farms were prevalent.

The next time you drive on Rengstorff, think about how different the area used to be when chickens were the majority of residents in the area!



Chickentown

A Bird's-Eye View

By Eric Flint
Special Contributor

Detail of the Corner of Charleston and Independence, Mountain View, in 1930
SOURCE: Flight C-1289, frame Z7, 12/1930. Courtesy of UCSB Library Geospatial Collection.

My name is Eric Flint and I'm a new member of the MVHA. Recently, I took an anthropology/archaeology class at Foothill for the fun of it. As a result of the class, I became interested in the early history/prehistory of the Mountain View area. I've lived in Mountain View for almost 25 years now, so I figured it was finally time to learn more about the history. Initially, I started looking at maps and then aerial photos. The MVHA has a very nice collection in the History Room at the public library. (That's where I met MVHA President Pamela Baird, which led indirectly to this article). But the photos in the History Center still felt hit-or-miss.

In my quest for more/better photos I ran across a reference to the Aerial Photography Archives of the University of California, Santa Barbara. Intrigued by the name, I looked into it, and I'm glad I did. Per their website, "The UCSB Library has more than 4,500 flights which add up to more than 2.4 million individual images." While obviously not all of them cover Mountain View, a surprisingly large number actually do. The images are relatively well indexed, and maybe even better, many are already digitally scanned and available for download in the public domain.

In keeping with the theme of this newsletter, I searched for photos of the "Chickentown" area from 1930s. Aerial images from flight (C-1289) consist of 14 images of the northwest corner of Mountain View taken in December 1930. The photos were commissioned by the City of Mountain View. Makes you wonder what they were thinking about back then, as that area was way outside of city limits at that time.

At first the photo looks like lightly inhabited farmland. But this area touches on many parts of the history of Mountain View. The land was still unincorporated Santa Clara County. The Bayshore Highway and portions of San Antonio Road didn't exist. At first it was very hard to figure out what I was viewing as so much has changed over the last 91 years. I eventually recognized Charleston Road, and after that, everything else slowly fell into place. The main road T-ing into Charleston in the middle of the frame is what is now Rengstorff. The road to its immediate left is Independence Avenue.

While interesting and fun, the real power of the archive is found when you zoom in on a photo. The following image has Charleston running at a diagonal from upper right to middle left. One can begin to make out more details such as the homestead on the left with what looks like cows milling around in a feed lot. More relevant to us are the collection of long narrow buildings on relatively small lots. This is the beginning of Chickentown, centered on Independence Avenue.

This photo confirms that yes, indeed, this area was Chickentown. It was exciting to confirm, through the magic of this historical photo archive, the history of an area of Mountain View that few people know.

In the next newsletter I'll describe more about how I've searched and utilized photo archives.

Summer 2021 Snapshots

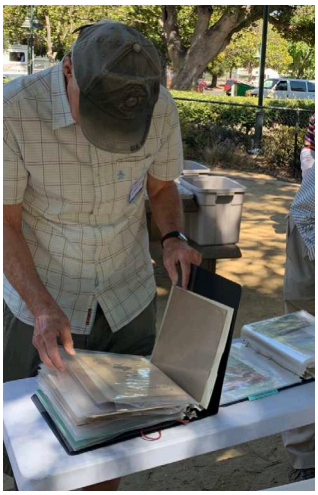


A Historical Reunion!

Summer Ice Cream Social

On August 1, 2021, the Mountain View Historical Association reunited for our first in-person event since winter 2020. Due to the ongoing pandemic, we didn't return to our normal gathering place, the historic Adobe Building, but instead met safely outdoors at Rengstorff Park. Members and guests browsed through binders of new items added to our archives over the past year-and-a-half, chit-chatted beneath the park's beautiful oak trees, enjoyed It's-It ice cream sandwiches, and learned about the park's rich history as the former home of Mountain View's Mexican-era founding family, the Castros. We enjoyed our afternoon in the park, and hope to return again for another event in the future!















On September 18, 2021, the Kiwanis Club of Mountain View and the City of Mountain View sponsored the third annual Harvest History Festival at Heritage Park. The festival showcased Immigrant House, a classic windmill, and "Greenie," Mountain View's 1957 Chevy ranch truck. It also featured garden tours, canning demonstrations, live bluegrass music, bubble entertainment, and a puppet show.

The purpose of the Harvest History Festival is to educate the community about Mountain View's historical agrarian past, and to introduce folks to the community of nonprofit organizations that support the history and natural environment of our area. Many thanks to our MVHA volunteers, who turned out to help with the event!



MVHA Board Members pictured here enjoyed their time representing our organization at the Harvest History Festival.



MVHA Board Members pose for a photo with former Board Member and current City Councilmember Alison Hicks (second from right) at the 30th Anniversary Celebration of the Rengstorff House's restoration.

On August 29, 2021, the MVHA Board of Directors was honored to attend a small in-person celebration of the 30th anniversary of the restoration of the Rengstorff House, hosted by the City of Mountain View and the Friends of "R" House. Members of our Board of Directors enjoyed small group (and masked) tours of the house and remarks from City officials that commemorated this milestone in the house's 154-year history.



History Happening Now

Ameswell Hotel Entrance (Courtesy Ameswell Hotel)

New Ameswell Hotel Takes Its Inspiration from the Past

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

The recently opened Ameswell Hotel takes its inspiration from the local history of Moffett Field, NASA, and Mountain View itself. The name is a combination of "Ames" and "wellness." The local Ames Research Center is named in honor of Joseph Sweetman Ames, a physicist and one of the founding members of NACA (the precursor of NASA). Wellness is a primary focus of the design and operation of the hotel.

Speaking with Philip Maritz, managing director with the developer Broadreach Capital Partners, I wanted to learn more about the choices made in the references to local history and how those decisions were made. Philip, a history major in college, spoke about his concern that "history is being lost" and there being "no shortage of inspiration" in the development and detailing of the hotel.

Broadreach originally considered engaging a hotel brand franchise, but when a larger property could be developed, they decided to create a unique independent hotel property. The development team worked with the San Francisco interior design firm of BAMO. Their focus was to create a "local sense of place" for the hotel. After selecting Ames and NASA as a design theme, the team created the "A" logo, which is in the shape of the iconic Hangar One at Moffett Field.

Asked what resources were used for research, Philip replied that it was "easy and fun. So much information is available online." Images of blimps from the 1930s, P-3 Orion airplanes, and all manner of flight provided inspiration, some of which are used throughout the hotel.

In August, my husband and I (with other community members) were lucky to have a private tour conducted by Keith Battaglia, director of Sales and Marketing for the Ameswell. Many fascinating notes and details of the hotel were explained. The restaurant bar is named Roger (for the radio communication affirmation) and the coffee shop is called Flyby.

The Library focuses on all sorts and types of flight. Decorative objects included are photos of Amelia Earhart, an astronaut

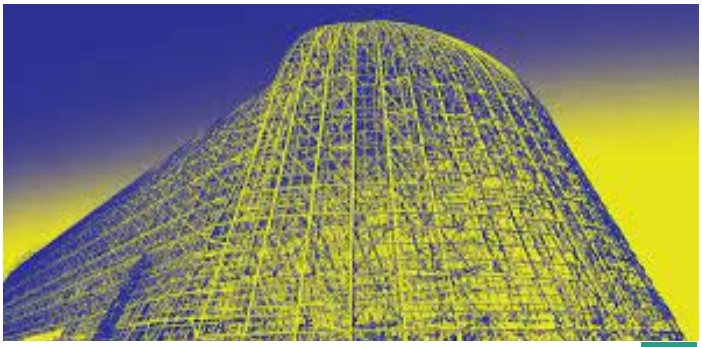


Ameswell Hotel Library (Courtesy Ameswell Hotel)

on the moon, and the Akron blimp tethered to the ground at Moffett Field. A stuffed pheasant is placed on a shelf above a futuristic-looking aircraft. Other items refer to NASA and aerospace. According to Philip, the Library was designed as a place to "escape, relax, and stimulate your mind."

Artwork curated by Art Advisory Service for the public spaces includes artistic images taken from the Hubble deep space telescope and other interactive pieces inspired by nature. QR codes will be placed by each piece to name the artist and explain the creation of the artwork.

When asked if visitors will notice the local inspiration for the hotel, Philip replied "there will be people who won't notice, 60% will be moderately interested, and 20% will be fascinated." The hotel aims to be a local community resource, not just a place for people from out of town to stay. Currently the hotel hosts live music on Thursday evenings and plans to offer numerous events and opportunities for local residents to enjoy.



Hangar One Photo Artwork displayed at the Ameswell Hotel (Courtesy Ameswell Hotel)

Membership Report

By IdaRose Sylvester
Membership Committee Chair

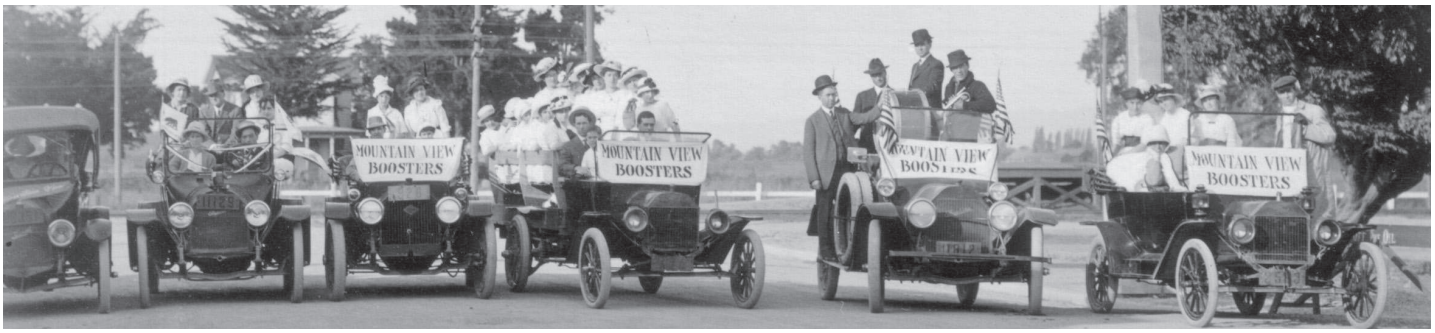
Membership as of October 6, 2021

Honored Members	1
Life Members	108
Family Members	74
Single Members	77
TOTAL MEMBERSHIP	**260**

Welcome new Life Member, Ben Lindahl! Welcome new members, Carol Donahue and Eric Flint! We really appreciate you!

Many of you have received this newsletter with a unique cover asking you to please renew. As Membership Chair, I know that life, especially lately, is really busy, and it's easy to miss your membership renewal notices. We would love to get your membership up to date! Renew now and you'll be good through all of 2022. If you think we've made a mistake, or you have any questions, reach out to me, IdaRose Sylvester, at idarose@mountainviewhistorical.org.

For all members, we'll be doing our big membership renewal push by the end of 2021, so check your emails! We're moving to a once a year renewal for all members, in January of each year, instead of having renewals be at individual join dates. We hope this makes it easier for everyone to stay connected.



MEMBERSHIP FORM

The MVHA welcomes new members! By becoming a member, you are making a special investment in our mission to preserve and share Mountain View history with the community, conserve priceless archival materials at the History Center, and hold memorable public events throughout the year. You can also join and renew online at **www.mountainviewhistorical.org**. Please support the MVHA, and join us today!

- ☐ New Membership
- ☐ Membership Renewal
- ☐ Single Membership: *$15/year*
- ☐ Family Membership: *$25/year*
- ☐ Life Membership: *$200*

Name(s): _____

Street Address: _____

City: _____

State: _____ Zip Code: _____

Telephone: _____

Email: _____

☐ *I'm interested in volunteer opportunities*

☐ *I'd like a print-edition subscription of the newsletter. (To save paper and costs, the default subscription is a digital emailed newsletter.)*

Please make checks payable to:
Mtn. View Historical Association

Mail this form to:
Mountain View Historical Association
c/o IdaRose Sylvester
P.O. Box 252
Mtn. View, CA 94042

Thank you!

AUTUMN/WINTER

November 3

Wednesday, 6:00 p.m. to 7:30 p.m.

MVHA Special Board Meeting

Virtual Zoom meeting

Our board is planning to meet more frequently in 2022 and will discuss our schedule and other items at a special November board meeting. All interested members are welcome to attend! Email info@mountainviewhistorical.org for login.

November 7

Sunday, 1:00 p.m. to 3:00 p.m.

MVHA Fall Event

Centennial Plaza, 600 W. Evelyn Ave, Mtn. View

More information on page 11!

December 8

Wednesday, 5:30 p.m. to 7:30 p.m.

MVHA Fall/Winter Board Meeting

Virtual Zoom meeting

All interested members are welcome to attend! Email info@mountainviewhistorical.org for login.

February 6

Sunday, Time TBD

MVHA Winter Event & Meeting

Location TBD

More information in our winter newsletter!

Looking Back: Photos from the Archive



This c. 1903 photo of the west side of the 100 block of Castro Street shows a variety of early Downtown Mountain View buildings, each with a fascinating story. One was destroyed by the Great San Francisco Earthquake of 1906. Another was eventually relocated across the railroad tracks and used as an apartment building until the early 2000s. One building was demolished, and one still stands today as the oldest non-residential building in Mountain View, if not all of northern Santa Clara County! Do you know which one is which? At our Downtown Mountain View walking tours on November 7, all will be revealed! Details on Page 1.

EST. 1954

MOUNTAIN REVIEW

MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

P.O. Box 252
Mountain View, CA 94042

WEB: www.mountainviewhistorical.org
EMAIL: info@mountainviewhistorical.org

FIRST-CLASS MAIL

Join the conversation on Facebook!
"Like" us at ***www.facebook.com/MVHistory***
for updates on MVHA Events and historic trivia,
and to interact with other members online.

Save a tree and see the newsletter in:
Full-Color
Email **mvha.newsletter@gmail.com**
to receive the digital edition of our newsletter.